Where Defenses Break and Attacks Convert: An xG Analysis of the 2025/26 Premier League

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Introduction:

Defensive quality in soccer is harder to measure than it looks from a league table. Goals against tells you what happened on the scoreboard, but not whether the defense was actually under siege or just unlucky. The same logic runs in the other direction. A team that scores three goals on two shots had a good day, not a good system. Expected goals, or xG, fills both gaps. Each shot in a match gets a probability of becoming a goal based on the location, the type of attack, and a handful of other factors. Summing those probabilities across a season gives a cleaner read on the chances a team created and the chances they allowed.

This report uses 2025/26 Premier League shot data from Understat to study both sides of the ball. On defense, we ask where on the pitch teams are most vulnerable and which attacking positions exploit them most. On offense, we ask how efficiently teams and players convert their chances, who performs best in late-game pressure, and which passer-shooter partnerships drive the most dangerous attacks. How do Premier League teams differ in where they concede expected goals, who they concede them to, and what tactical or player-level factors explain these differences?

Analysis

Data

Each row in the Understat data is a single shot. We restrict the sample to the 2025/26 Premier League season and drop penalty kicks. Penalties have a fixed xG near 0.76 and reveal nothing about defensive structure.

Understat does not record player positions, which is the main limitation of the dataset. We built a player-to-position map by hand, sorting close to 300 players into one of nine roles ranging from center back to striker. Goalkeepers are excluded from the position analysis.

Where teams concede on the pitch

Figure 1 shows where each Premier League team gives up xG, drawn as a heatmap on a half-pitch. We bin shots into a 30 by 20 grid, sum the xG values inside each bin, and shade each cell by intensity. The color scale is shared across all twenty panels with a log scaling, so a few extreme cells do not wash out the rest of the grid. Without this, a clean Liverpool sheet would look just as red as a leaky Burnley one.

Good defenses are concentrated. Arsenal, Liverpool, and Manchester City show light coloring with tight clusters near the penalty spot. The shots they do allow come from the heart of the box, but there are not many of them. Weaker teams look different. Burnley, West Ham, and Wolves show heavier saturation that spreads outward into the half-spaces and toward the edges of the area. Their opponents are getting shots from a wider variety of positions, not just the central zones.

Which positions teams concede to

Figure 2 turns to who is taking those shots. The horizontal axis is each team's total xG conceded across the season, and the vertical axis is the xG conceded specifically to opposing strikers. A diagonal line shows the league-average ratio between the two. Teams above the line give up a larger share of their xG to strikers than the league norm.

Burnley sits in the worst corner with both the most total xG conceded and the most xG conceded to strikers. Bournemouth, West Ham, Sunderland, Everton, and Fulham also sit above the line. Manchester City is at the other extreme, allowing only around 7.7 xG to strikers across the season despite a total above 35. Wolves are an interesting case. Their total xG conceded is high but their striker share is below average, which suggests their back-five shape crowds the central forward but lets damage through from wider attackers or runners from midfield.

Attacking Output and Finishing Efficiency

The attacking analysis draws on shot-level data from the 2025/26 Premier League season, aggregated at both the player and team level. For each player, total xG accumulated across all shots was compared to actual goals scored, producing an xG delta, which is the difference between what a player *"should"* have scored based on chance quality and what they scored in the season. The same aggregation was performed at the team level to assess overall finishing efficiency.

Figure 3 plots each team's total xG generated against actual goals scored, with a 45-degree parity line separating overperformers from underperformers. Strikingly, nearly every team finished below the line, suggesting a league-wide tendency to underperform xG this season. Tottenham was the notable exception. At the top end, Chelsea led the league in xG generated (64.6), followed by Manchester City (61.9) and Arsenal (61.7), though all three underperformed their xG in actual goals. Wolverhampton Wanderers were the most wasteful in relative terms, scoring just 23 goals on over 30 xG.

Individual Clinical Finishers

Figure 4 plots goals against total xG for every player, with the top 10 goal scorers labeled, distinguishing high-volume chance accumulators from genuinely clinical individuals. Erling Haaland leads both in chance accumulation and efficiency (22 goals on 23.1 xG) and his shot map (Figure 5) explains why: almost all his attempts originate from central positions inside the six-yard box, producing the highest xG-per-shot average among top scorers at 0.227. Antoine Semenyo stands out as the clearest overperformer, netting 15 goals on just 11.2 xG.

Clutch Finishing

A separate analysis isolates shots taken in the 80th minute or later with the score within one goal, high-pressure situations where finishing quality is most consequential. To isolate performance in genuinely high-stakes moments, we define "clutch" situations as shots taken in the 80th minute or later, moments where a conversion has an outsized impact on the result. Players were ranked by their clutch xG delta (clutch goals minus clutch xG) among those with at least 0.5 cumulative clutch xG, filtering out small sample noise. This surfaces players who consistently outperform their expected output when games are on the line, a quality that aggregate season statistics tend to obscure.

Table 1 shows the results. Mohamed Salah leads with a clutch delta of +1.55, scoring 3 goals from chances worth only 1.45 xG in those situations, meaning he is converting late-game chances at roughly double the rate their quality predicts.

Attacking Situations and Supply Chains

Not all xG is created the same way. Open-play xG is generally considered a more reliable indicator of tactical quality, whereas set-piece xG depends more heavily on specific personnel and delivery routines. Figure 6 plots shots taken against total xG generated per team, colored by xG-per-shot quality. Chelsea generated their league-leading xG from just 414 shots at the highest quality rate of 0.156 per shot, while Manchester United generated similar xG from 480 shots at a much lower rate of 0.123, indicating a volume-dependent attack rather than a system built on chance quality.

Finally, passer-shooter pairs were aggregated to identify the most dangerous creative partnerships. Table 2 shows Mathis Cherki supplying Haaland tops the list at 3.63 xG created. Haaland's presence in three of the top five pairings underlines that his output draws quality service from multiple teammates rather than relying on a single supply relationship.

Conclusion

Defensive performance is not just about how much xG a team concedes, but also where those chances occur and who takes them. Strong defenses limit high-quality chances to a small central area, while weaker teams concede from a wider range of dangerous positions. Some teams are especially vulnerable to strikers, pointing to structural weaknesses in central defensive coverage rather than just overall defensive volume.

The attacking side tells a parallel story. Nearly every team in the league underperformed their xG this season, and the gap between chance creation and conversion separates clinical finishers from high-volume accumulators. Late-game performance reveals a further layer, with players like Mohamed Salah converting clutch chances at roughly double the rate their quality predicts. Future research could incorporate tactical data such as formations or player tracking to better explain these patterns. Extending the study across multiple seasons would test whether the underperformance of xG observed this year is a structural shift in finishing or a one-season anomaly.

Appendix A: Figures and tables

Figure 1:

xG Conceded by Zone - All PL Teams (2025/26)

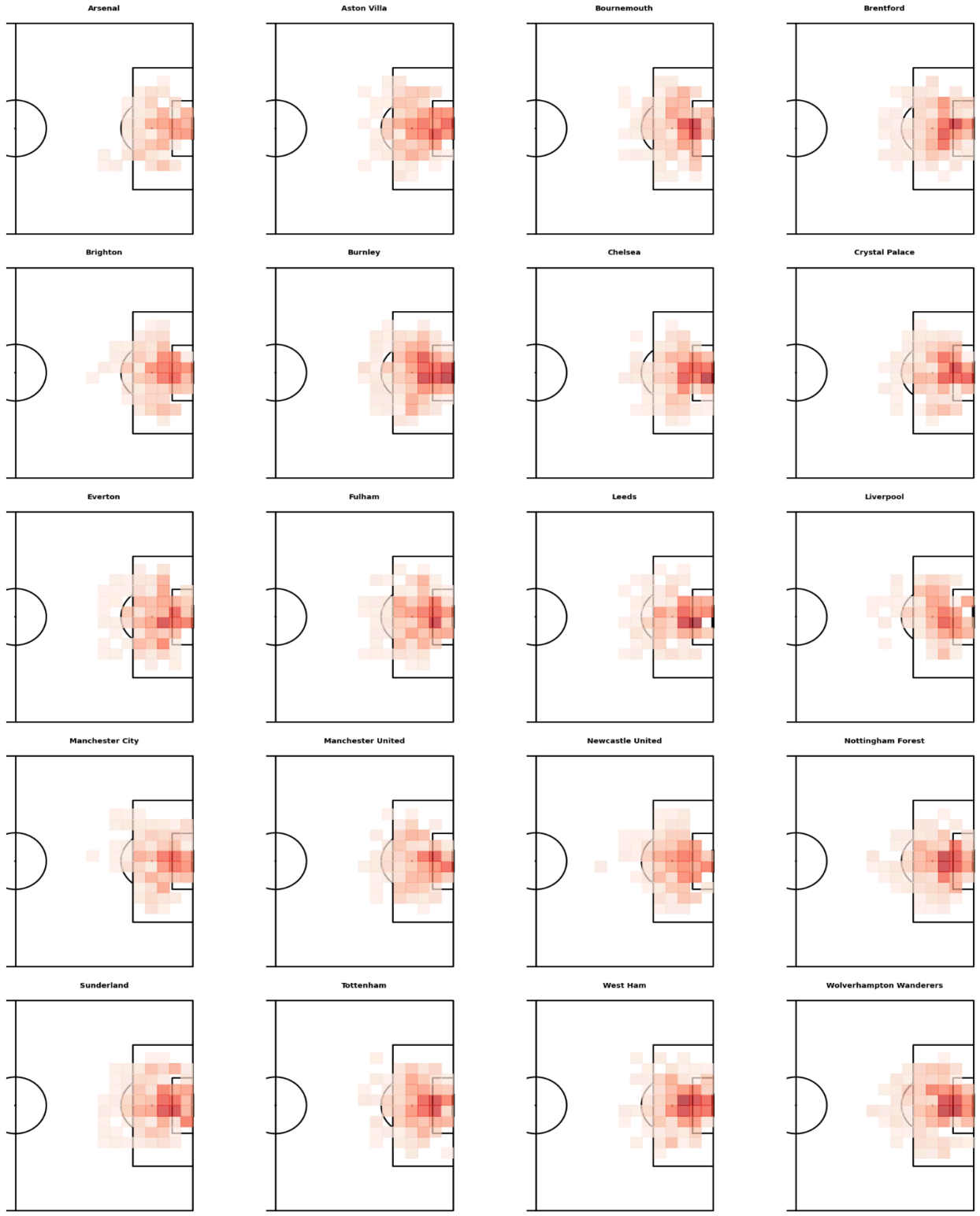

Figure 2:

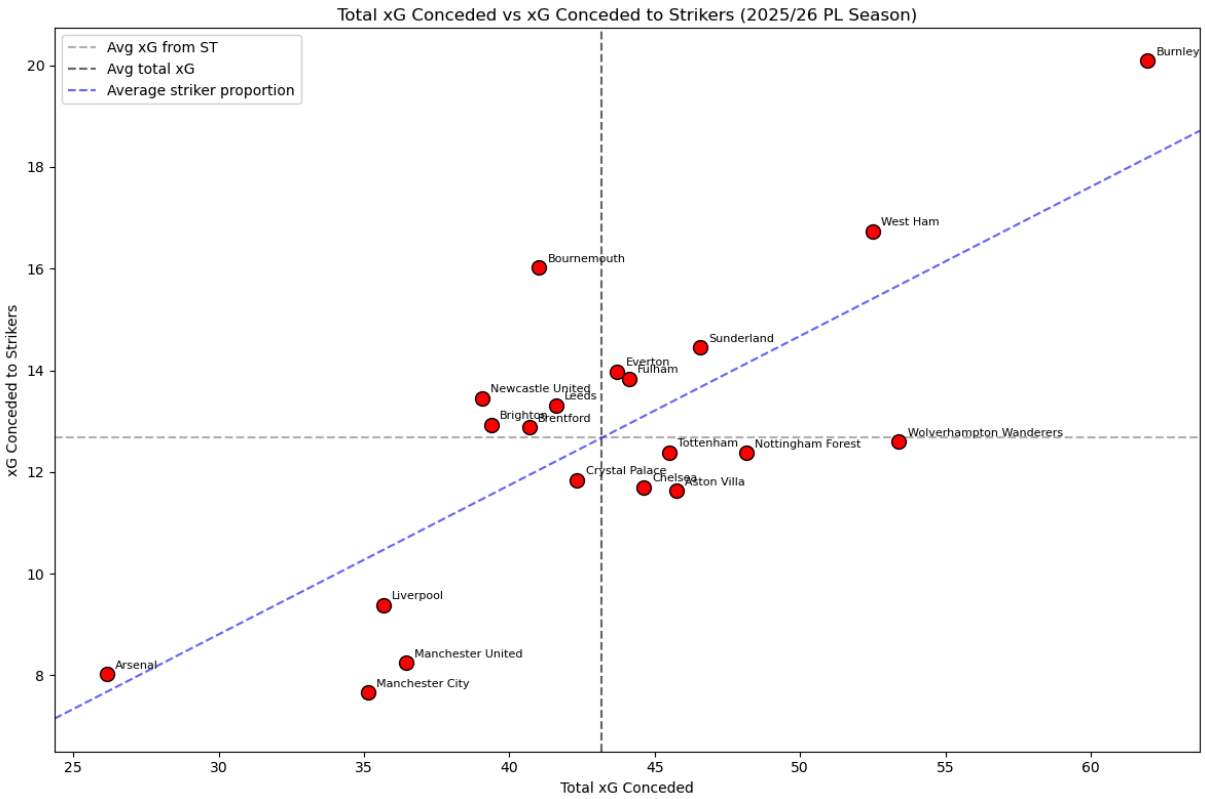

Figure 3:

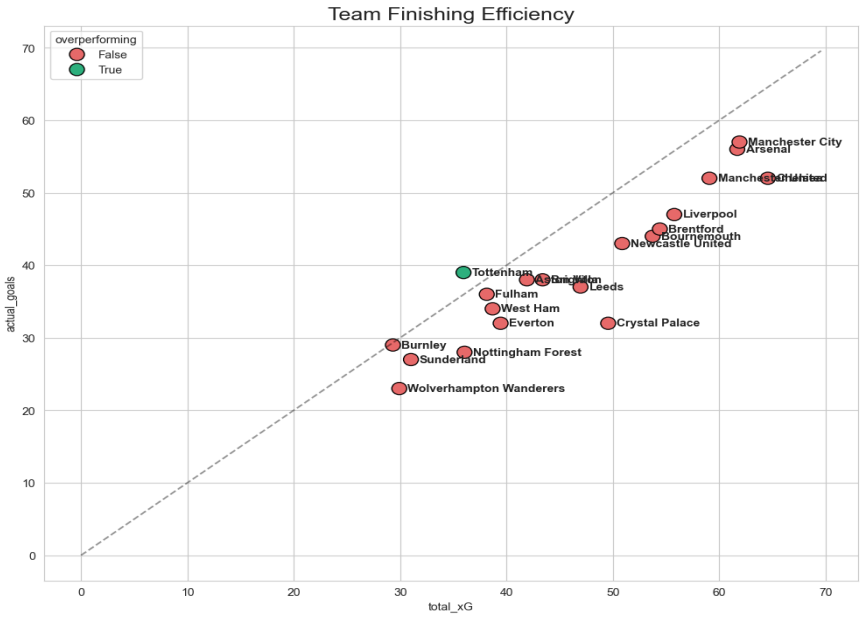

Figure 4:

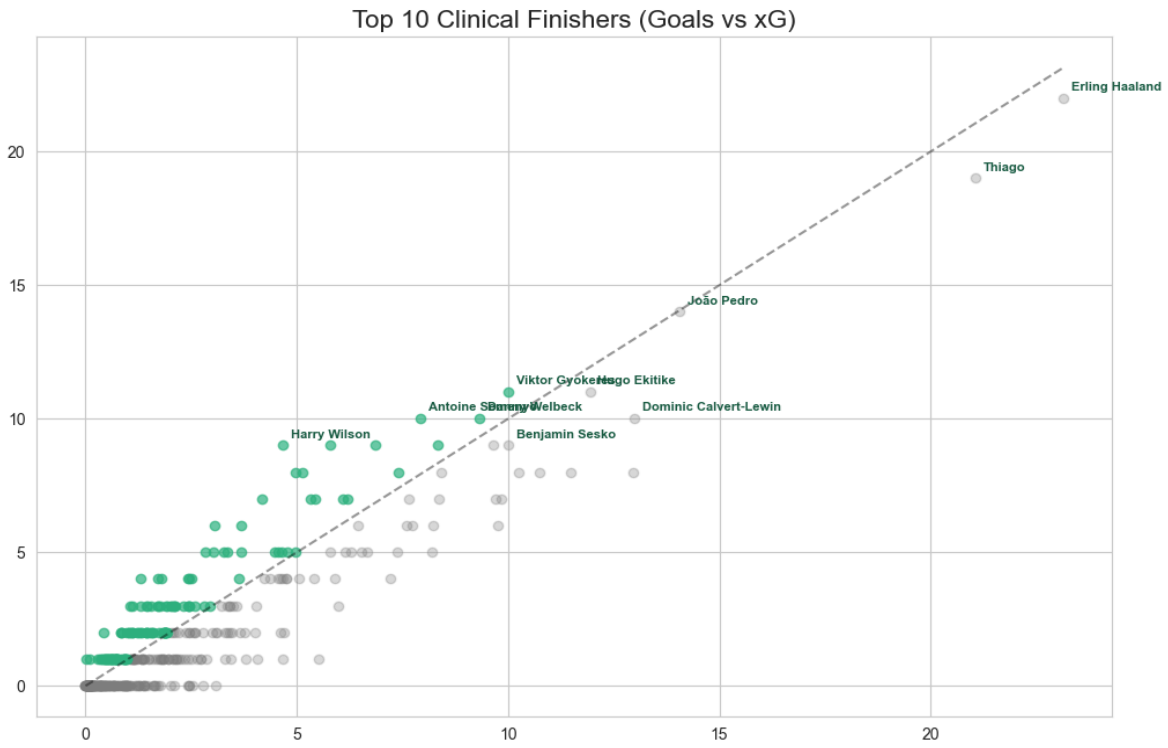

Figure 5:

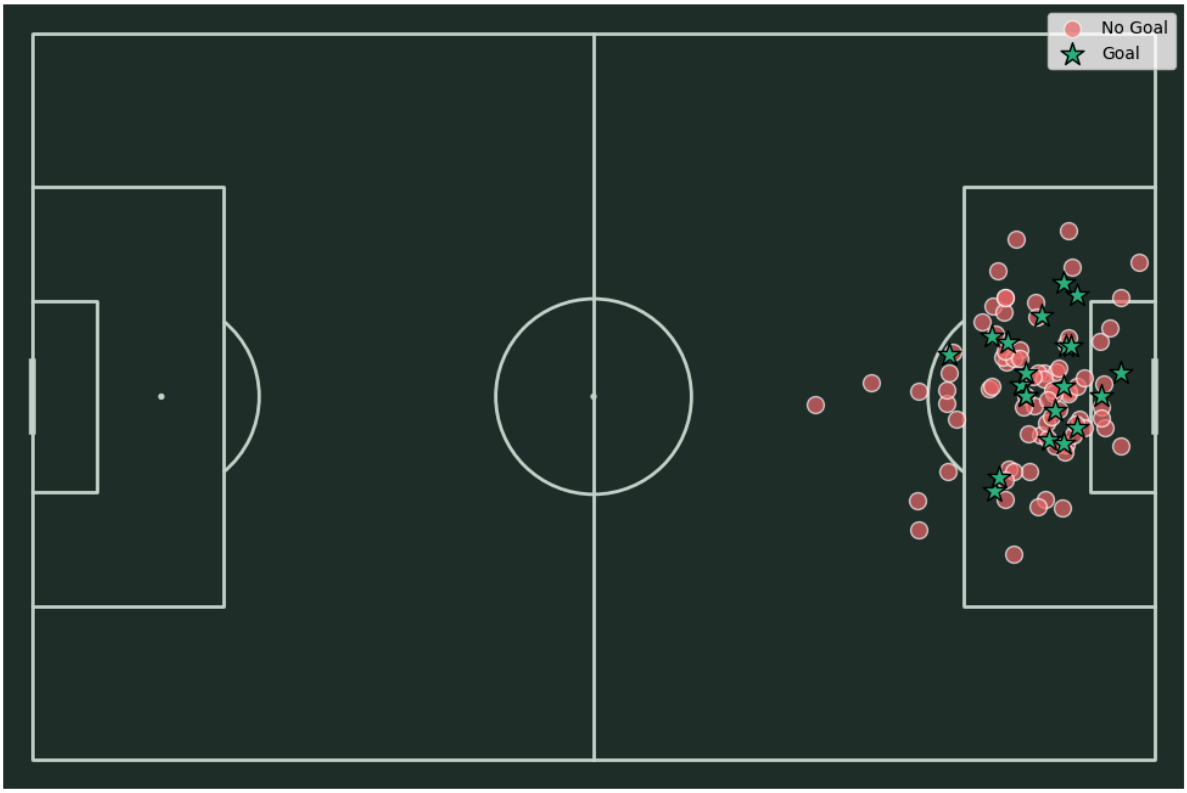

Figure 6:

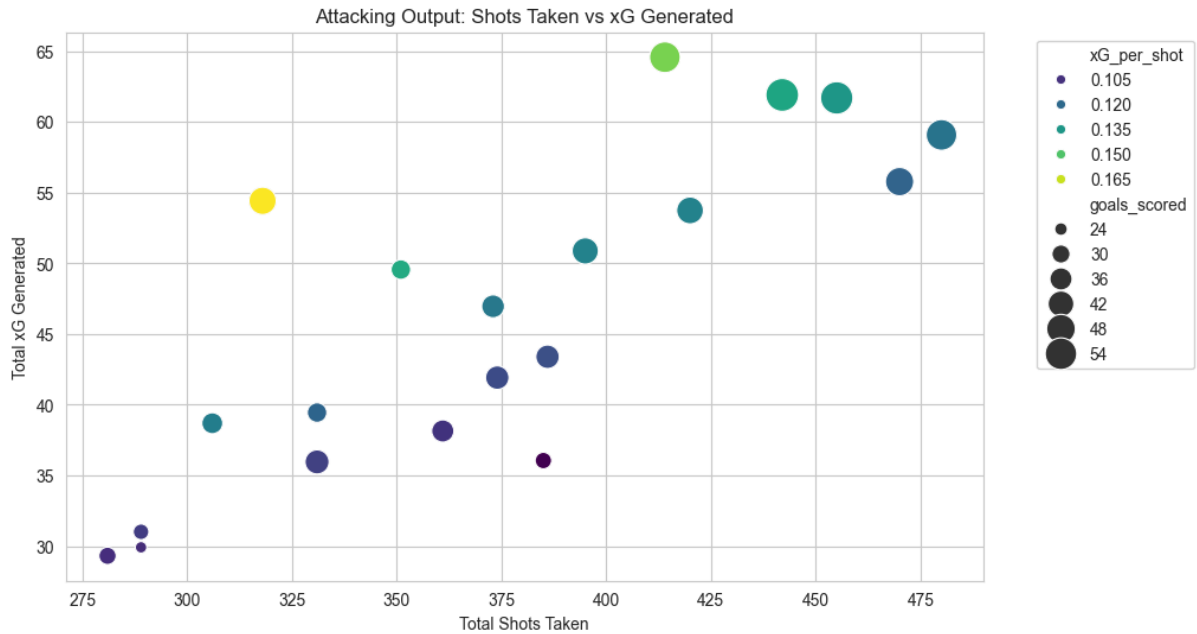

Table 1:

Top 5 'Clutch' Finishers (Late Game Overperformers):

	player	clutch_xG	clutch_goals	clutch_delta
220	Mohamed Salah	1.454233	3	1.545767
259	Richarlison	1.625489	3	1.374511
308	William Osula	0.665667	2	1.334333
134	Jan Paul van Hecke	0.841736	2	1.158264
21	Benjamin Sesko	0.844359	2	1.155641

Table 2:

Top 5 Most Dangerous Partnerships (By xG Created):

	passer	shooter	total_xG_created	actual_goals
1812	Mathis Cherki	Erling Haaland	3.628544	2
1480	Kevin Schade	Thiago	2.910977	3
2228	Phil Foden	Erling Haaland	2.665958	1
252	Bernardo Silva	Erling Haaland	2.504374	1
1990	Morgan Rogers	Ollie Watkins	2.456526	2

Who feeds Viktor Gyokeres the best chances?

	passer	shooter	total_xG_created	actual_goals
374	Bukayo Saka	Viktor Gyokeres	1.318218	0
914	Gabriel Martinelli	Viktor Gyokeres	1.091324	2
1552	Leandro Trossard	Viktor Gyokeres	0.972572	0